Getting students on board with retrieval

Explain, demonstrate and build habits

Use an explanation and demonstration of retrieval when students see quizzes as judgement or prefer familiar rereading. Help them understand why attempting recall is part of learning.

How to do it well

1 Identify the concern. Find out whether students fear scores, do not understand the purpose or lack a useful retrieval routine.

2 Explain simply. Describe how trying to recall differs from rereading and why feedback follows the attempt.

3 Demonstrate with accessible content. Let students experience independent recall and checking without making the task a test of self-worth.

4 Establish the routine. Use predictable instructions, achievable demands and respectful responses to errors.

5 Reinforce the learning purpose. Show how previous gaps return in future practice and how students can use retrieval independently.

What this sounds like

“You may recognise this when reading it, but can you produce it without the page? Try first; the gap tells us what to practise, and the feedback helps repair it.”

Classroom example. A teacher explains why recognising a paragraph is different from producing its key idea without looking. Pupils try an accessible recall task, receive feedback and meet the same knowledge again later. The routine demonstrates a learning purpose and treats errors respectfully, helping build trust in retrieval beyond a single explanation.

Top tips that make the technique work

Explain the learning purpose. A low-stakes attempt strengthens access to knowledge and shows what to revisit.

Demonstrate a fair comparison. Use a simple experience to contrast recognition with generating an answer, without promising an instant universal result.

Normalise effort. Difficulty recalling is information about the learning, not a reason to avoid the attempt.

Make success attainable. Use well-taught content and a useful prompt where total failure would prevent productive practice.

Keep the routine consistent. Repeated experiences of attempt, feedback and improvement build more trust than a single motivational speech.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Explain the purpose and give corrective feedback.	A public ranking that undermines the low-stakes message.
Use mistakes to guide future practice.	Claiming effortful failure is always beneficial.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

Barton — Getting students on board with retrieval